

YOUR BREASTMILK: A UNIQUE GIFT FOR YOUR PREMATURE BABY



Breastmilk is the most important gift that you can give your premature infant. Here are some reasons why:

Why is my breastmilk best?

The milk you provide is something **only you** can give your premature baby. Your breastmilk contains **invaluable nutrients and immune factors** that help your baby grow and develop well. Your milk also helps **protect your baby** while his/her immune system is still developing. Premature babies get **extra benefits from mom's breastmilk** including decreasing their risk for a serious infection in the intestines called necrotizing enterocolitis (NEC).

How do I make and provide breastmilk to my baby?

Breastfeeding is different when you have a premature baby. Premature babies are not strong enough to feed at the breast so they receive expressed breastmilk instead.

Breastmilk is expressed with the help of a breast pump.

We highly **recommend pumping as soon after birth** as you are able. Your bedside nurse will help you get started pumping as soon as you are ready. **Frequent pumping (every two to three hours)** will mimic the frequency of a newborn's feeding pattern and promote a good milk supply.

Where do I get a breast pump?

There will be a **pump will be at your baby's bedside for you to use in the hospital**. If you do not have a pump at home yet, your nurse can contact the social worker to help you **get a pump at little or no cost to you**. **You will need a breast pump at home by the time you are discharged from the hospital.**



Why can't I just use donor breastmilk?

Your fresh milk is best for your baby. Donor human milk must be pasteurized for safety—pasteurization kills the infection-fighting live cells. It is a good **bridge** when a mother is **actively pumping and trying to increase** her own milk supply but it is **not an equal substitute**.

Where can I pump at the hospital?

At UAB, **you are able to stay 24/7 in your baby's room**. We encourage you to **pump at your baby's bedside**. Being closer to your baby while pumping can increase the amount of milk you produce. There are also lactation rooms available for pumping.

How can I learn more about breastfeeding, how to store my milk, and what to do if I have a problem?

A lactation consultant will automatically meet you after your baby is born to help guide and support you through your breastfeeding and pumping journey. The **lactation consultant will provide you with a larger packet** that has information about the benefits of breastfeeding, **increasing your milk volume, using a breast pump, hand expression, and storing your milk**. The lactation consultant will also be able to answer your questions about breast-feeding and pumping. If you'd like to speak with a lactation consultant, please notify your bedside nurse, or call 205-975-8334.

BREASTFEEDING IS AN INVESTMENT IN HEALTH, NOT JUST A LIFESTYLE DECISION

BENEFITS FOR INFANTS

Infants who are breastfed have reduced risks of:

- Asthma
- Obesity
- Type 1 diabetes
- Severe lower respiratory disease
- Acute otitis media (ear infections)
- Sudden infant death syndrome (SIDS)
- Gastrointestinal infections (diarrhea/vomiting)
- Necrotizing enterocolitis (NEC) for preterm infants



BENEFITS FOR MOTHERS

Breastfeeding can help lower a mother's risk of:

- High blood pressure
- Type 2 diabetes
- Ovarian cancer
- Breast cancer



Breastfeeding provides unmatched health benefits for babies and mothers. It is the clinical gold standard for infant feeding and nutrition, with breast milk uniquely tailored to meet the health needs of a growing baby. We must do more to create supportive and safe environments for mothers who choose to breastfeed.

Dr. Ruth Petersen, Director of CDC's Division of Nutrition, Physical Activity, and Obesity